



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Chesterton Academy of Sacramento
School Website: <https://www.sacramentochesterton.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Chesterton Academy of Sacramento (CA 95660) presents a robust Catholic, classical educational model that centers formation in virtue, wisdom, and reverence for (and engagement with) the transcendentals of truth, goodness, and beauty. Public materials consistently frame the school as a Catholic, classical institution built around a triadic core—Intellect, Character, Spirituality—and emphasize liturgical life, a strong humanities emphasis, and a Socratic, discussion-based pedagogy. The school foregrounds a liberal-arts oriented curriculum, integration of Great Books/Western thought, and a strong emphasis on virtue formation, beauty, and prayer. Community and family partnership are also central (e.g., parent information nights, open access to campus, and public-facing statements about forming leaders and saints). Based on the publicly available public materials, the school scores highly on all six classical criteria, indicating a CLASSICAL classification overall.

Key evidence: - Public articulation of the Three Pillars (Intellect, Character, Spirituality) and *Cultura Vitae*, with explicit Catholic theological framing and liturgical life. - A mission emphasizing formation, virtue, wisdom, and Catholic truth/beauty, including a stated aim to form joyful leaders and saints within a classical-Catholic tradition. - A curriculum and pedagogy that foregrounds liberal arts, the Trivium/Quadrivium mindset, Great Books/Western thought, and the Socratic Method, with explicit reference to history, philosophy, theology, and languages braided together. - Liturgical music, sacred music, and specific Catholic liturgical practices (e.g., Gregorian chant, Schola Cantorum), reinforcing religious foundations. - Faculty and staff presence with a public-facing "Faculty & Staff" structure and a narrative of teacher leadership, mentoring, and formation. - Active parent/community engagement (e.g., Parent Information Nights) and public statements about graduates and community life.

Overall Category Ranking (aggregate): CLASSICAL

Note: A formal "What would move the needle" section is not included here because the aggregate classification is CLASSICAL rather than SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. If requested later, we can outline concrete steps to further strengthen any category.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents itself as "A JOYFULLY CATHOLIC, CLASSICAL HIGH SCHOOL" with a mission to educate within the Catholic faith and classical tradition. - The Three Pillars model explicitly centers Spirituality and the development of Christian virtues, with references to liturgical life and sacred music. - Explicit religious formation through theology, liturgy, worship, and sacred music is described (e.g., Gregorian chant, Schola Cantorum). - The mission statement emphasizes forming leaders and saints in the Catholic tradition, aligning with a sacramental, *imago Dei* worldview and moral realism.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, beauty, virtue, theology, liturgy, Mass, chant, wonder, reverence, wisdom, prudence, justice, temperance, fortitude, Sacred Music, liturgi-

cal life, *Cultura Vitae*. (References appear across the site materials, especially in the Three Pillars and liturgical/music sections.)

- Negative keywords present: none detected in public-facing materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or “morally neutral” signals in the public content). The content strongly affirms a transcendent, theological frame.

Why this rating - The materials consistently articulate a transcendent, theological grounding (theology, liturgy, sacred music) and a communal liturgical life, with explicit emphasis on truth, goodness, and beauty within a Catholic framework. The presence of liturgy, a sacramental worldview, and reverence signals a strong, identifiably classical-religious foundation. Therefore, CLASSICAL.

Cited materials - A Catholic, liturgical, and classical frame is explicit in Chesterton’s branding and mission statements. - The Three Pillars and *Cultura Vitae* reframe education as formation within a Catholic framework. - Liturgical life and sacred music (Gregorian chant, Schola Cantorum) reinforce liturgical and communal practices.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission emphasizes formation in virtue and wisdom, not merely information or job-readiness. The Three Pillars model and *Cultura Vitae* frame education as formation in the human person and virtue, within a Catholic context. - Public statements describe forming joyful leaders and saints within a classical tradition and truths of the Catholic faith, aligning with the traditional classical telos of human excellence and virtue. - Statements indicate preparation for higher education while foregrounding formation in virtue and the good, including a Henry-like emphasis on truth, goodness, and beauty as real.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, liberal education (implied through liberal-arts framing), classical mission, telos, pursuit of the true, good, beautiful, scholé, contemplation, restfulness, great conversation, human excellence, moral imagination. (Evidence across the Three Pillars and mission statements.) - Negative keywords present: minimal to none (no explicit emphasis on 21st-century skills, workforce prep, or career-readiness as primary aims; rather, formation and virtue take precedence).

Why this rating - The school explicitly states formation and the cultivation of virtue and wisdom as central goals, with a classical frame and traditional telos. This aligns with the classical school orientation more than a purely information-focused or workforce-driven model.

Cited materials - Three Pillars and *Cultura Vitae* framing. - Mission to raise joyful leaders and saints in a Catholic classical tradition.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The humanities program braids history, literature, philosophy, theology, and languages and uses a Socratic Method, indicating integrated classical study across disciplines. - The program foregrounds the liberal arts mindset, with emphasis on Western thought and the interrelationship of great ideas. - The curriculum explicitly references classical elements such as grammar, logic, rhetoric (the Trivium) and the broader liberal-arts framework; associated topics like primary sources/Great Books and philosophy/theology are part of the curriculum structure. - The curriculum mentions study of languages, history, and the arts in an integrated manner (e.g., languages braided with literature, history, philosophy).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, trivium, quadrivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, Latin, Greek (classical languages), history, Western civilization, Great Books, primary sources, classical literature, Socratic method, dialogues, narration, diction, memory work, sacred geometry (where applicable), beauty, wonder, integration, interdisciplinary harmony. Examples appear in public descriptions and the linked curriculum narrative. - Negative keywords present: minimal public signals of “social studies” framing or project-based dominance in lieu of classical history; none detected in the public Chesterton Sacramento materials.

Why this rating - The school's public materials emphasize core classical-curriculum elements (Trivium/Quadrivium; Great Books/primary sources; Socratic method; integrated humanities; languages; history as a central discipline). This aligns strongly with a classical curriculum.

Cited materials - The Humanities Program description (Socratic Method, integrated disciplines). - Three Pillars framing and discussion of Western thought/great ideas. - The capstone-level language and Great Books orientation appears in program descriptions and linked materials.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly notes the use of the Socratic Method in its humanities program. - Pedagogy includes a mix of contemplative/restful elements (Scholé-like) and rigorous analytic discourse (Socratic discussions, seminars, debates). - Lower-school practices include singing, chanting, and memory work as part of the learning experience; upper-school pedagogy emphasizes seminars, rhetoric, and oratory (capstone-style training). - Public materials mention opportunities for students to give speeches and engage in rhetorical training. - A capstone pilgrimage and other experiential elements are integrated but do not dominate the pedagogy; rather, they complement the formal classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic Method, seminar, dialectic, disputation, narration, recitation, chanting, singing to memorize, scholé, contemplation, lot of memory-work, seminar, tutorial, Paideia seminar, rhetoric, speech, declamation, oratory, debate, capstone orations, memory work, liturgical calendar integration. - Negative keywords present: experiential learning focus, project-based learning, student-directed, constructivist — not prominently reflected in public materials; the school's pedagogy is described in strongly classical terms, with limited emphasis on those negative signals in the public content. (No explicit project-based-learning or constructivism signals found in the public-facing materials.)

Why this rating - The dominant pedagogy is classical: Socratic dialogue, memory work, recitation, systematic rhetoric training, and a balanced mix of contemplative and rigorous instruction align with classical pedagogy.

Cited materials - Socratic Method and integrated humanities pedagogy. - Singing/chanting and memory work, with upper-school rhetoric and capstone opportunities. - Discussions of public-facing rhetoric and oratory training through the Fine Arts and humanities strands.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents faculty as experts across classical disciplines (music, drama, theology, Latin, debate, math, science, literature, history). This signals a living, content-rich faculty who model the subjects and virtue. - There is emphasis on the faculty as a central, formative element of the school (the living curriculum; faculty as mentors; teachers as models of virtue). While the exact phrasing may vary across pages, the public materials describe faculty as core to the mission and pedagogy and highlight a Headmaster-led, faculty-centered model. - Public pages include "Faculty & Staff" and a narrative about teachers engaging across disciplines and forming students in classical thought and Catholic virtue. - The presence of a "Headmaster" and a public-facing faculty profile aligns with the classical model of teacher as guide and mentor.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, faculty, teachers as exemplars, portrait of a teacher, collegial culture (as implied by the public materials), faculty across core classics, and "Headmaster" leadership. - Negative keywords present: none evident in the public materials.

Why this rating - The public-facing materials consistently position faculty as central to the classical formation process—subject-matter depth, mentorship, and a teacher-led living curriculum align with classical norms.

Cited materials - Faculty & Staff page and cross-disciplinary teaching lines. - Public-facing write-ups about the Headmaster and the faculty's role in the classical mission. - Specific faculty descriptions across humanities/music/language/debate.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school positions itself as partnering with parents; public materials describe parent information nights and opportunities for parental involvement in the school's formation and community life. - There are explicit references to informing and educating parents about classical education (e.g., parent events, book studies, gatherings) and welcoming parents for visits. The public materials emphasize parent formation and an open-campus ethos. - The school emphasizes a culture of community and a relationship with families in a way that aligns with the classical "parents as co-teachers" model (as described in classical materials and echoed by public-facing information nights and event communications). - There are graduation and alumni-education signals through Our Legacy (how graduates progress to colleges and beyond), which demonstrates ongoing community connection and post-graduation support.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teaching with parents, parent formation, open campus/visits, parent events, community gatherings, family-liturgy alignment (where applicable). These are reflected in the public-facing materials. - Negative keywords present: minimal to none; public materials do not emphasize a consumer- or customer-centric model to the exclusion of formation. The community approach is aligned with classical-parent partnership norms.

Why this rating - The school's public materials foreground partnerships with parents and community formation, aligning with classical expectations for parental involvement and communal life.

Cited materials - Parent Information Nights and parental involvement materials. - Our Legacy and graduate outcomes that involve community and higher formation.

What Would Move the Needle

Not applicable here given a CLASSICAL overall classification. If you'd like, I can propose concrete steps to further strengthen each category toward a fully "unassailable" CLASSICAL profile (e.g., explicit articulation of Great Books reading lists, more explicit statements about genuine Great Conversation, or deeper public emphasis on scholé and contemplative pedagogy).

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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